

Northwind Home: answers people can trust, from the company's own records

Domain FDE Pre-Work Deep Track • Blue Data Consulting • Customer experience, supply chain and finance

The business

Every day, Northwind's three back-office teams ask the same kinds of question. Some are about **records**: how many, which, how much. Some are about **rules**: what is allowed, who approves, what happens if a deadline is missed. The answers exist, but they are scattered across systems and documents owned by different teams.

Team	Where its answers live	A question it asks every week
Complaints desk (CXM)	Complaint records; the vulnerable customers and contact consent policies	How many open complaints come from vulnerable customers?
Returns centre (SCM)	Returns records; the grading, disposition and vendor claims policies	Which damaged items can still be claimed from the vendor?
Billing (Finance)	The refund ledger; the refund policy	Can this refund be paid without approval?

Two kinds of source

Source	What it looks like at Northwind	What makes it hard to use
Records (structured)	Tables in back-office systems: customers, accounts, orders, complaints, refunds, returns, consents	Short, cryptic names; codes instead of words; the same fact stored twice
Policies (unstructured)	Written documents, each owned by one team: refunds, delays, grading, vendor claims, consent	Long, updated by their owners, and rarely read end to end

Where it goes wrong today

- **Legacy data is easy to misread.** The returns system stores the grade as a code from 1 to 3, with nothing to say that 3 means damaged. Vulnerability is recorded on the customer and, by an older system, on some accounts, and the two disagree. A reasonable reading of the wrong column gives a confident, wrong answer.
- **Policies are answered from memory.** On Day 1 the agent was asked what compensation a five-day delay earns, and what grade C means. It had no way to look, so it guessed. People do the same when the document is hard to find.
- **Answers cannot be checked.** “Three items” or “the team lead approves it” arrives with no source, so nobody can tell a lookup from a guess.
- **Copying everything is not the fix.** Pasting whole tables and every policy into each request is slow and expensive, and buries the one fact that matters.
- **Data belongs to its owners.** Billing will not hand its ledger to every tool that asks. Access has to go through something Billing controls.

Who is affected

Stakeholder	What they need
Complaints, returns and billing leads	A correct answer in seconds, with the record or policy it came from
Data owners (each team, and data engineering)	Their data reached through a door they control, read only, with clear meanings
Legal and compliance	Every answer about a rule traceable to the policy that says it
Head of operations	Trusted answers at a cost that still works at thousands of questions a week

The business question

How do people get answers they can trust, drawn from the company's own records and policies, with each source controlled by its owner, and at a cost that scales?

How this is tackled in practice, with a grounded agent in Google ADK, is in [usecase1_day6.pdf](#). All names, figures and data are made up.